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Knowing and Experiencing God's Love

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Knowing and Experiencing God's Love

Galatians 2:16.-3:3

In the process of coming to understand how much God really loved me and seeing love as the foundation for His rescue of humanity, I also came to understand how God had created us human beings. He made us to be recipients and givers of His great love. God designed us in His image—to be like Him—so that we could have a loving relationship with Him and others. God intends that all of His creation be subject to His loving will through us.

When God created us, He made us to be of three parts: spirit, soul and body. Our spirit is a resting place for God's Spirit on earth. Our soul is comprised of our mind, will and emotions. And our body is the earthly house for the spirit and soul.

In God's creative design, His Spirit is meant to fill our spirit, our spirit is meant to lead our soul and our soul is meant to direct our body. But when Adam chose to eat the fruit from the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil, he severed his spirit relationship with God and therefore had to live by the leading of his own soul. The human soul—with its new-found knowledge of good and evil—was now in charge. Thus, the "flesh" (Galatians 3:3)—the soul and body together—was no longer led by God. When we live in the flesh, we live by laws because the independent soul, cut off from the Spirit can only live by rules.

Adam's fall destroyed the way God had created humanity to live. We were not created to live in the flesh. We were created to live in the Spirit. Jesus provides for us to be born-again of the Spirit—by faith. And he made a way for us to live our lives on earth continually walking in the Spirit—in love.

Paul spoke this truth to the Galatians. He shared with them how he lived his life on earth in faith and love. He confronted them with these words: "You foolish Galatians! ... After beginning by means of the Spirit, are you now trying to finish by means of the flesh?" Just as I had done in my Christian life, the believers in Galatia had received Christ by faith, but for living life on earth, they were falling back into living by the law—into living in the flesh.

Read Galatians 2:16-3:3.

Chapter 2

16 Know that a person is not justified by the works of the law, but by faith in Jesus Christ. So we, too, have put our faith in Christ Jesus that we may be justified by faith in Christ and not by the works of the law, because by the works of the law no one will be justified.

17But if, in seeking to be justified in Christ, we Jews find ourselves also among the sinners, doesn't that mean that Christ promotes sin? Absolutely not! 18If I rebuild what I destroyed, then I really would be a law-breaker.

19For through the law I died to the law so that I might live for God. 20I have been crucified with Christ and I no longer live, but Christ lives in me. The life I now live in the body, I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me. 21I do not set aside the grace of God, for if righteousness could be gained through the law, Christ died for nothing!

Chapter 3

1You foolish Galatians! Who has bewitched you? Before your very eyes Jesus Christ was clearly portrayed as crucified. 2I would like to learn just one thing from you: did you receive the Spirit by the works of the law, or by believing what you heard? 3Are you so foolish? After beginning by means of the Spirit, are you now trying to finish by means of the flesh?

Questions

1. The word justify (see verses 2:16 and 17) means to “declare to be right” or to “make righteous in the sight of God.” Is it possible to be justified by the Old Testament law? Why or why not?
2. What does it mean to you personally to be “justified ... by faith in Jesus Christ”?
3. According to Galatians 2:20, how is Paul living his life on earth?
4. Notice that in verse 20, Paul is not struggling to crucify himself. He says, “I have been crucified with Christ.” In what ways do we sometimes try to crucify ourselves? What kind of results do these efforts typically bring?
5. Paul had persecuted and killed those who believed in Jesus Christ. Yet in verse 20, he refers to Jesus as “the Son of God, who loved me.” Describe God’s love as you think Paul might have experienced it.
6. In what ways does knowing and experiencing God’s love make it possible to live the life Paul is describing?
7. In your own words, what is Paul warning the Galatians about in verses 3:1-3?
8. In verse 3:3, what do you think Paul means when he refers to the “flesh”?
9. How is it possible to begin in the Spirit—to be born again and receive eternal life through faith—and yet to still be relying, in some way, on the flesh to live life on earth?

10. Recall and describe a time when you personally tried to accomplish something “by means of the flesh”—when you let your soul choose the “good” it wanted to do and tried to do that “good” in your own strength. What was the result?
11. In what ways might you as a believer be relying on a New Testament version of the law or set of rules to guide your life?
12. What might help you more fully embrace God’s perfect love?

Reflection

Visit the Forever Loved website (Forever-Loved.org) and listen to the song, “The Love of God.” Imagine Paul—the one who had persecuted and killed believers but had come to know the love of God—singing beside you. Let the love of God wash over you as the words sink into your heart.

If you cannot access the video, read the lyrics to the third verse, found below.

Could we with ink the ocean fill,
And were the skies of parchment made,
Were every stalk on earth a quill
And every man a scribe by trade,
To write the love of God above,
Would drain the oceans dry.
Nor could the scroll contain the whole,
Though stretched from sky to sky
O love of God, how rich and pure!
How measureless and strong
It shall for evermore endure
The saints and angels song.

Thank you for downloading this free resource!

We're grateful you've taken this step in your spiritual journey. Your growth in Christ encourages us, and we pray this has been a blessing—strengthening your faith, deepening your understanding of God's Word, and equipping you to live for His glory.

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Thank you again for partnering with us in the Great Commission. May the Lord continue to fill you with joy, peace, and purpose as you walk with Him.

In Christ,

The JesusOnline Ministries Team

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